



him I've worked hard for it. *Meri bhi koi life hai* (It's my life too)."

A step up the economic ladder

The star raider's prolific career has coincided with the birth and growth of the PKL. Modelled on the Indian Premier League (IPL), the PKL turned a rustic, relatively raw *maati se juda hua khel* (sport of the soil) into a hit television product.

For E. Prasad Rao, PKL's technical director, seeing players like Chaudhari, Aslam Inamdar (Puneri Paltan's PKL-winning captain), Siddharth Desai (a towering raider with Telugu Titans), and many others benefit financially from the league was one of two primary objectives.

"When we started PKL, the highest amount a player earned was ₹12 lakh, and we were incredibly happy

Big stakes: Action from last season's PKL final between Puneri Paltan and Haryana Steelers. Pics: PKL

with that," Rao remembers. "Now, that's what our junior-most players are getting. Some used that money to get a house, support their family, or even purchase a buffalo. It was big money, but they didn't spend it on themselves. That's what has changed over time. Players are now able to do all of the above while also spending on their own development — hiring trainers, physiotherapists, dieticians, and more."

The 2014 edition of PKL began with eight franchises, growing to 10 by 2017. League officials envision further expansion in the years to come, though those plans are yet to take shape. In the decade that has passed in PKL's life cycle, Rao believes that a key objective — potentially even the most binding one — has been fulfilled.

From strength to speed

"Look at cricket. Eighty per cent of the population that loves this game doesn't play it but stays connected in one way or another. Our biggest goal was to bring kabaddi to the common man in a similar manner. It's our own sport, born in India. Everyone here understands the basics of the game. Maybe some specific rules might be hard at first. But it never managed to carve a space in people's hearts. The game inherently has an excitement we needed to tap. The message we wanted to convey was to make people realise that such a fierce game is our own," he says.

Chaudhari was the young blood when the league began 10 years ago. Before him came legends like Anup Kumar, Rakesh Kumar, and Iran's Meraj Sheykh, who were the faces of the sport just after the turn of the millennium. Stellar performances, title wins, and a game whose international shape and